

# briefly...

## THE YELLOW BOAT

Cast: 4 men, 3 women. Recommended for audiences aged 8 and older, parents, families and adults.

THE YELLOW BOAT is based on the true story of David and Sonja Saar's son, Benjamin, who was born with congenital hemophilia, and died in 1987 at the age of 8 of AIDS related complications. A uniquely gifted visual artist, Benjamin's buoyant imagination transformed his physical and emotional pain into a blaze of colors and shapes in his fanciful drawings and paintings. The story of THE YELLOW BOAT is a glorious affirmation of a child's life, and the strength and courage of all children.

A Scandinavian folksong tells of three little boats: "One was blue, one was red, and one was yellow as the sun. They sailed far out to sea. The blue one returned to the harbor. The red one sailed home too. But the yellow boat sailed up to the sun." Benjamin always concluded his bedtime ritual by saying "Mom, you can be the red boat or the blue boat, but I am the yellow boat." This remarkable voyage of Benjamin was extensively developed and widely produced in America for several years, always to ovations.

### Playwright: DAVID SAAR

Is the Founder and Artistic Director of Childsplay, Inc., an award winning theatre for young audiences in Tempe, Arizona. THE YELLOW BOAT premiered at Childsplay in 1993 and received the Distinguished Play Award in 1998 from the American Association of Theatre and Education. Saar has also overseen and directed a number of new plays in development including THE YELLOW BOAT, HUSH: AN INTERVIEW WITH AMERICA and PHENOMENAL SMITH. His community work includes a three year term on the Tempe Municipal Arts Commission, he is a board member of the US branch of ASSITEJ: the International Children's Theatre Association and is active in the American Association for Theatre and Education.



# The Yellow Boat

by

David Saar

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## Characters:

Benjamin  
Mother  
Father

A chorus of 4 actors, play the following roles:

Actors #1 and #2: male  
Actors #3 and #4: female.

They will play the following roles.

Chorus  
School children  
School teachers  
Parents  
School administrators  
Kids  
Eddy  
Joy  
Doctors

## Playwright's Note:

In the early drafts of the play, the chorus parts were called "T.P.'s" - shorthand for "Transformational Potential." While their names have changed, they continue to serve this purpose in the play. They play all the above roles, but can also be used, for example, to "create drawing" - or anything else the director might want to use to tell the story.

Time is fluid in the play and should be approached cinematically rather than realistically. We can and will move forward, back, and across time. "*Time shift*" means just that - a cinematic shift to another moment.

The drawings that Benjamin describes in various monologues can be "drawn" in the air or on a blank piece of paper with a prop crayon.

The boat mentioned in some stage directions refers to a set piece used in the Tempe and Seattle productions, a small, movable Yellow Boat that was manipulated to become an ambulance, a bed, etc. There are many scenic solutions; this is provided as just one example.

The Yellow Boat was first presented by Childsplay, Inc. at the Tempe Performing Arts Center, Tempe, Arizona in October, 1993. It was directed by Carol North. The dramaturg was Suzan Zeder; associate dramaturg, Judy Matetzschk. Scenic design by Greg Lucas, lighting design by Amarante Lucero, costumes by Susan Johnson-Hood. Original music composed and performed by Alan Ruch. The cast was as follows:

|                 |                  |
|-----------------|------------------|
| Benjamin:       | Jon Gentry       |
| Mother:         | Ellen Benton     |
| Father:         | Dwayne Hartford  |
| Joy:            | Debra K. Stevens |
| Eddy/Chorus #1: | D. Scott Withers |
| Chorus #2:      | Alec Call        |
| Chorus #3:      | Alejandra Garcia |
| Chorus #4:      | Helen Hayes      |

A touring version of The Yellow Boat was first presented in February, 1994, by The Metro Theater Company, St. Louis, MO. It was directed by Jim Hancock. The dramaturg was Suzan Zeder; associate dramaturg, Judy Matetzschk. Scenic design by Nicholas Kryah, lights designed by Jack Brown, costume design by Clyde Ruffin, original music composed and performed by Al Fischer. The cast was as follows:

|                 |                 |
|-----------------|-----------------|
| Benjamin:       | Jennifer Makuch |
| Mother:         | Grace Adellen   |
| Father:         | Nicholas Kryah  |
| Joy:            | Gina Ojile      |
| Eddy/Chorus #1: | Eddie Webb      |
| Chorus #2:      | Al Fischer      |

A study guide is available from  
Childsplay, Inc.  
P.O. Box 517  
Tempe, AZ 85281

THE YELLOW BOAT is also available in an abridged version more suitable for touring.

Playbooks and royalties are the same for each.

\* \* \* \*

More information about THE YELLOW BOAT and Benjamin Saar may be obtained from Kathy Krzys. She is the curator of the child drama collection at ASU in Tempe, Arizona.

Please contact her by e-mail: [kathy.krzys@asu.edu](mailto:kathy.krzys@asu.edu)

*(Soft light, sound swirl. The time is past, present, future. Lights come up on a boy who will become Benjamin playing with a toy boat.)*

BOY: It began . . . 10-9-8-7-6-5-4-3-2-1: Blast-off!

*(Vocalized sounds of rocket launching.)*

Beep, beep, beep, beep . . .

CHORUS #1 - #4, MOTHER and FATHER: It began before the beginning . . .

*(The boy's play holds stage alone for a moment, and then others, the characters who will become the parents, doctors, and community members become part of the playing space. Their voices overlap, and build.)*

#1: This is a story about . . .

#3: This story is about . . .

#4: Not an ordinary story . . .

#2: It happened . . .

#3: Did it happen?

FATHER: How could it happen?

#4: This is a story about . . .

#3: This story is about . . .

FATHER: Not an ordinary story . . .

MOTHER: It happened . . .

#2: Did it happen?

ALL: It happened.

*(The Boy looks around at this gathering for the first time.)*

BOY: This is a story about . . . me.

*(From the perimeter of the playing space the other characters begin to vocalize different parental labels.)*

MOTHER: Mother . . .

FATHER: Father . . .

#4: Momma . . .

#2: Pappa . . .

#3: Mommy . . .

FATHER: Daddy . . .

#1: My Old Man . . .

BOY: It began before the beginning with a sort of choosing . . .

*(Choral voices continue to offer up a variety of "parental choices" from which the boy will make his selection.)*

MOTHER: Mommy's here.

#1: You're getting so big.

#3: What did you do in school today?

#2: Brush your teeth.

FATHER: Way to go! I'm so proud of you.

#4: Do I have to stop this car?

FATHER: That's my boy.

MOTHER: Sweet dreams.

BOY: Mom? Dad?

*(Boy shifts his focus to father and mother. The scene "shifts" to a more realistic style.)*

FATHER: You're what?! Are you sure?

MOTHER: I'm sure.

FATHER: Positive? You're sure? Whooh . . . ! This is great! It is really great, isn't it?

MOTHER: I've never felt so happy; . . .

FATHER: Can you feel him yet?

MOTHER: No, but I know he's there.

FATHER: 'He.' We both said, 'he'!

MOTHER: I know.

FATHER: What does . . . he feel like?

MOTHER: He feels like himself.

BOY: *(The boy points to mother and father.)*

You will be my Mom. And you, my Dad. This is a story about us. And it takes . . .

*(The chorus begins a vocalized list of "time choices" which overlap and build. The "choices" may be repeated if desired.)*

#4: Forty-eight years, sixty-seven years, fourteen years, three years . . .

#2: Ninety-six years, seventy-nine years, sixty-seven years, thirty-two years . . .

#3: Eleven months, five months, seven months, three months . . .

#1: Fourteen days, four days, twenty-three days, nine days . . .

*(He stops the time swirl with his announcement.)*

BOY: It takes: eight years, four months, twenty-nine days . . . That's enough!

*(This launches a "birth dance" with Mother, Father and Benjamin. As Benjamin names each color, chorus members swirl colored silks into the air, transforming the playing space into a swirl of color.)*

I see . . . red.  
I hear . . . blue.  
I feel . . . purple.  
I taste . . . green.  
I . . . choose . . . yellow.

*(Mother gives birth to a small yellow doll that "becomes" the baby Benjamin. Mother and father use the doll as baby while the actor playing Benjamin voices and reacts for him.)*

FATHER: It's a boy!

MOTHER:- A boy.

BENJAMIN: My birthday. April 19, 1979.

*(The chorus form a cradle of ribbons in which the doll Benjamin is rocked, and become various doctors, and friends.)*

#2 and #4: Congratulations!

#4: Yes, it's a boy. That I'm sure of.

#2: Yup, a boy.

#3: Ooohhhhhh! He's so little. I keep forgetting how little they always are.

#1: Now don't wait too long to have a brother or sister for this one, . . .

#3: Is'm's Mumsy's and Dadsy's little itsy bitsy . . . ooh, look, he's smiling at me!

FATHER: I think it's gas . . .

*(The ribbon cradle breaks away, and the parents are in another space.)*

MOTHER: A beautiful boy.

FATHER: Seven pounds, six ounces.

MOTHER: His fingers are right, and his toes are on . . . The nurse says he's the most beautiful child she's ever seen.

FATHER: She says that to everyone.

MOTHER: Still, today . . . I went down to the nursery . . .

FATHER: . . . just to check out the competition?

MOTHER and FATHER: She's right.

FATHER: So what's his name . . . ?

MOTHER: His eyelashes are the longest . . . and his little fingers, look . . .

FATHER: The nurse says they'll hold him for ransom if we don't give him a name.

MOTHER: He's small, and wise, and . . . mine.

FATHER: And mine.

*(Mom gives baby to dad, who doesn't quite know what to do with him.)*

MOTHER: That's it!

FATHER: What?

MOTHER: His name. "Benjamin."

FATHER: Benjamin?

MOTHER: It works in lots of languages. Translate: Ben . . .

FATHER: "Son."

MOTHER: Ja . . .

FATHER: "Yes."

MOTHER: Min . . .

FATHER: "Mine."

*(Father cuddles his son and parents simultaneously translate his new name.)*

MOTHER: Son. Yes, he's mine!  
FATHER: Ben. Ja. Min.!

*(Benjamin begins a fussy cry, Dad gives doll back to Mom. They move to another space. "Busen lull" underscoring begins.)*

BENJAMIN: Once upon a time, there was a Mom, a Dad, and a little, teeny baby . . .

FATHER: Welcome, Benjamin.

BENJAMIN: And a song!

MOTHER: This is a story my mother used to tell to me every night before I went to sleep. It's about boats, and sails, and . . . it takes place in a harbor . . .

FATHER: far, far away . . .

*(The actor Benjamin "claims" the doll Benjamin and the*

*mother holds both in her arms to tell the story. From this point until doll Benjamin "grows up" to actor Benjamin, the doll is manipulated by the actor.)*

MOTHER: Now inside this harbor there were three boats. A red one. A blue one. And a yellow one. They all sailed far out to the sea, and the red one came back, and the blue one came back; but the yellow boat? The yellow boat sailed straight up to the sun.

*(Singing.)*

Busen lull, cook the kettle full,  
There sailed three boats from the harbor,  
The first was so blue,  
The second so red,  
The third was the color of the sun.

MOTHER and FATHER: Busen lull, cook the kettle full,  
There sailed three boats from the harbor,  
The blue carried hope,  
The red carried faith,  
The yellow filled itself with love.

FATHER: I sail the blue boat

MOTHER: The red one's for me . . .

*(The lullaby has almost put him to sleep.)*

BENJAMIN: I am the yellow boat.

*(He falls asleep. The music resolves. Parents "pull away" from the baby to work.)*

MOTHER and FATHER: Work time!

MOTHER: I'll weave you a sail . . .

FATHER: I'll write you a world . . .

BENJAMIN: *(Sleepily)* I'll do it myself!

*(Father and Mother separate to their individual work spaces. Mother weaves some of the colored silk ribbons, Father works on a new story. The chorus are used to help create these work environments or assist in the creation of the work itself - they are "transformational potential." Each parent works to rhythms which weave together and separate. The intention of this movement/music beat is to show the parents at work, and the baby Benjamin discovering that he has the power to interrupt that work. Use the following choral litany to underscore the scene - or figure out another way to do it!)*

#3 & #4: Shuttle, Beat. Shuttle, Beat. Shuttle, Beat. Shuttle, Beat. *(Repeat.)*

#1 & #2: Comma, Dot. Comma, Word. Comma, Dot. Comma, Word. *(Repeat.)*

*(Benjamin awakes, and watches the surrounding activity, perhaps joining in, or getting in the way, and then, tired of no one paying attention to him, starts to cry. Both parents come running, Benjamin gives them his most charming smile.)*

FATHER: What's wrong?

MOTHER: Oh, you're okay.

FATHER: Now, where was I . . . ?

*(They return to work, and after a short time Benjamin begins to cry, again.)*

MOTHER: *(Not wanting to interrupt her weaving.)*

Mamma's right here. *(To Father)* Can you see what he needs?

FATHER: Yeah, sure.

*(He tries to ignore the crying for a beat, so Benjamin intensifies his efforts.)*

FATHER: Okay, here's the scoop. I'll write the story, and you color it!

*(Father hands Benjamin a crayon, and the actor Benjamin manipulates it for the doll. Rhythm starts. Father returns to writing, and the story gets the interest of the chorus.)*

Now, once upon a time . . .

#1, #2, #3, #4: Hmmmmm?

FATHER: Once upon a time . . .  
In a . . . land-kind-of-place,  
Where the palm trees grew . . .  
And the sky was painted . . .

BENJAMIN: *(He chooses.)*

Blue!

FATHER: Blue?

BENJAMIN: Blue.

*(A bluesy kind of music is heard, the stage turns blue, and the chorus illustrates the color in movement as Benjamin colors.)*

#1, #2, #3, #4: Cool, cooler, coolest, blue, Smooth, soothing, blues . . .

FATHER: That's exactly what I mean.  
And the trees are painted . . .

BENJAMIN: *(Holding up another crayon.)* Green.

*(Change in sound as he colors, the stage turns green and the chorus explores "green" in movement.)*

#1, #2, #3, #4 It's a mean kind of green, like a scream in a dream, Like a . . .

BENJAMIN: Ghost . . . on Halloween . . .

*(They all react in Bella-Legosi style.)*

FATHER: No that isn't what I mean. Those trees are . . .

BENJAMIN: Red. And they're dead.

*(Blackout)*

FATHER and MOTHER: Hey!

FATHER: What's going on here?

MOTHER: What happened to the lights?

FATHER: I don't know. Maybe it's . . . Or the . . . ? Or maybe it's a kid?!?

*(Lights up and Dad finds the chorus in shaped positions representing the wall drawings that Benjamin has created. He is in their midst, happily drawing with the crayon. Dad takes the crayon from him.)*

MOTHER: What?

FATHER: Well, I gave him some crayons and, . . . uhhhh, he got a little carried away and scribbled across the wall and the light switch.

MOTHER: Is he alright?

FATHER: He's fine, but the wall's a goner.

*(She crosses over and looks at the damage.)*

MOTHER: Oh Benjamin . . .

*(Then looks more closely at the wall, assessing . . . )*

Oh . . . !

*(Father joins her.)*

FATHER: Oh . . . ? Oh . . . ! Look at the . . .

MOTHER: And the . . .

FATHER: Not to mention the . . .

FATHER and MOTHER: *(Appreciative)* Oh . . . , Benjamin . . .

MOTHER: That's a very nice drawing . . . , but it would be so much nicer on a piece of paper . . .

*(She hands him a sheet of paper. With her finger she defines the space of the paper.)*

Here. Draw here. You can draw from here to here, and from here to here.

*(Mother helps Benjamin draw a long line on the paper.)*

A nice, long line that connects from here to here, and from here to here.

BENJAMIN: Line?

MOTHER: Line.

*(Benjamin takes the crayon and draws a line.)*

BENJAMIN: Line.

MOTHER: Lovely!

*(Mother returns to her work. Benjamin begins to explore the concept.)*

BENJAMIN: Line! Here. Line here. Here. Line here. Here. Line here. Line!

*(Benjamin draws a long line right off the paper. Suddenly discovering another dimension, he abandons the paper*



*and moves into the third and fourth dimension, moving through space as he explores "line." The chorus illustrates his "line exploration" with colored elastics which they manipulate to create visible lines and shapes in space.)*

BENJAMIN: Line!  
#4: S-p-i-r-a-l.  
BENJAMIN: Line!  
#2: Straight!  
BENJAMIN: Line.  
#1: An-gle?  
BENJAMIN: Line!  
#3: Curving . . . .  
BENJAMIN: Line!  
#4: Squiggle!  
BENJAMIN: Line!

*(Benjamin is delighted by his line drawings and his explorations grow bolder and bolder. Finally Father notices, and calls to Mother.)*

FATHER: Look, look what he's doing!  
MOTHER: Those aren't just scribbles, those are shapes!  
BENJAMIN: Shapes?  
MOTHER and FATHER: Shapes!

*(A music and movement section follows. As Benjamin draws, the chorus illustrates with the elastics and his*

*parents help by naming the shapes.)*

MOTHER and FATHER: Square, triangle . . . . There's a circle . . .

BENJAMIN: Circle? Wavy circle.

*(The circle becomes so.)*

MOTHER: Lines and shapes for a . . .

MOTHER and FATHER: Picture!

BENJAMIN: Picture of . . . a tree!

*(#1 and #3 use yellow and orange elastics to make a tree.)*

A heart.

*(#2 and #4 use the blue and green elastics to make a heart shape that "beats.")*

A bow and arrow.

*(#1 makes the bow with yellow elastic; #3 Makes the arrow with the orange elastic which is "shot" through the heart, pulling the bow and #1 with it.)*

Lines and shapes and colors make a picture . . . of a house with about a million rooms.

*(#1 - 4 form an abstract shape with the elastics that has lots of room shapes.)*

Roof top, mountain top . . .

*(The house is transformed to a mountain.)*

Lines for a picture of a yellow sun,

*(The mountain is transformed into a sun.)*

BENJAMIN: Lines for a boat. Yeah! A yellow boat!

*(The elastics are formed into the shape of a small sail boat. Benjamin jumps onto the boat, and beckons his parents, all the while drawing with the crayon.)*

Come on board!

*(Mom and Dad come aboard. Benjamin finishes by drawing the round sun in the air above the boat.)*

BENJAMIN: Yellow Boat sailing . . . , sailing . . . , sailing . . . , to the sun! Stop!

*(The boat "disappears," and the chorus moves upstage.)*

New Drawing. Benjamin's Body!

*(Benjamin picks up the paper he was drawing on earlier, and begins to draw again. Mother and Father are seated on the boat with the doll. Benjamin begins to draw the story as the parents live it.)*

Here's a picture of Mom, and she's singing to me.

*(The Mother and the chorus begins to hum "Busen lull" softly in a minor key.)*

Then she sees something funny.

*(Benjamin "draws" a bruise.)*

MOTHER: Look at this bruise. It seems to hurt him if I touch it.

FATHER: So don't touch it.

MOTHER: What caused it?

FATHER: It's just a bruise. Stop worrying.

BENJAMIN: I cry. *(He does.)* Loud. Lots! They worry! *(He cries more.)*

MOTHER: He keeps crying, just keeps on crying . . .

FATHER: I'll change him.

MOTHER: He doesn't need changing.

FATHER: Colic?

MOTHER: Four nights straight? Something hurts!

*(Benjamin cries more.)*

FATHER: Teeth?

*(Very loud crying. Both react.)*

MOTHER: Something's wrong!

MOTHER and FATHER: Call the Doctor!

*(The boat piece becomes the ambulance. Benjamin draws as he tells.)*

BENJAMIN: I'm going to the hospital in an ambulance. Just me . . . and Mom, and Dad. Big Siren! Cars scoot out of the way . . . Fast. Neat! Then . . . Doctors!

*(Doctors enter with clip boards, and whisk the baby away from the parents. They are robotic, clinical; the parents are left waiting outside, overhearing what is being said.)*

DOCTOR #1: Hematocrit every two hours.

MOTHER: What? What does that mean?

DOCTOR #3: Two pints whole blood, . . .

FATHER: What's wrong?

DOCTOR #1: . . . and a CAT Scan.

FATHER: What are you testing?

DOCTOR #2: Wait here, please. Just a few more tests . . .

BENJAMIN: More checks.

*(Doctors move to continue exam.)*

DOCTOR #1: Left pupil, three millimeters: right pupil, four millimeters. Note.

DOCTOR #3: Check.

DOCTOR #1: Charted?

DOCTOR #4: Check.

DOCTOR #1: Irregular.

DOCTOR #3: Highly irregular.

DOCTOR #1: I don't understand all this bleeding.

*(Doctors #1 - #3 cross to Benjamin. He tears a piece of his drawing paper, and hands it to one. Each "reads" the test result, each says "Hmmm?," and passes it to the next. The last to receive it is Doctor #2.)*

BENJAMIN: Then they figure it out.

*(Doctor #2 announces to the parents.)*

DOCTOR #1: Blood tests confirm that your son has . . . Classic hemophilia, Type A.

MOTHER: What does that mean?

BENJAMIN: It means my blood isn't like everyone else's. It's missing the "Stop Bleeding Stuff." So, when I get a cut or bump inside, it doesn't stop bleeding. It just keeps dribbling and drabbling . . . like a leaky faucet.

FATHER: What do we do?

DOCTOR #1: We'll begin the infusion procedure immediately. Check the weight and order up . . . one hundred and sixty units of Factor 8.

MOTHER: What?

DOCTOR #1: Factor 8.

FATHER: What does that do?

*(#1 and #3 swirl multiple red ribbons into the air, the separate blood sources that are then "mixed" to create the factor.)*

BENJAMIN: It's this really great stuff that works like a bunch of plugs to stop the bleeding. It's really strong because lots of people's blood gets mixed up to make it.

MOTHER: Where does it come from?

DOCTOR #1: From thousands of blood donors. Excuse me. We have to infuse him with the factor!

*(The infusion process is set up with a long length of knotted ribbons. This is the Factor 8 which is infused into the dolls body. Two chorus members control the ribbon movement in such a way that it looks like the stream of red is being infused into the doll's body. One doctor holds the doll, another holds the syringe and guides the blood line into the doll.)*

BENJAMIN: *(As he draws it.)* The first time they poke me, I cry. Poke! Owwww.

*(The doctor with the syringe "pokes" the doll, searching for a vein. Actor Benjamin "cries out" "Owww" with each attempt.)*

Poke! Owwww . . .

DOCTOR #1: Once more.

BENJAMIN: Poke! Owww . . . Poke!

DOCTOR #1: Bull's eye!

*(The infusion process begins. The parents speak from the waiting room.)*

MOTHER: He's stopped crying.

FATHER: Is everything alright?

DOCTOR #1: Everything is under control.

FATHER: How often will he need to go through this?

DOCTOR #1: Whenever he has a bleed. Each patient is different.

MOTHER: Is it safe?

DOCTOR #1: What?

MOTHER: That . . . Factor?

DOCTOR #1: Factor Eight is completely safe. Almost finished. Done.

FATHER: Are you sure he'll be okay?

DOCTOR #1: He can do anything any other child can, with just a few precautions. Trust me. He'll have a normal life.

*(The "baby" is returned to the parents. All except the family exit.)*

MOTHER: A "normal life." What's that supposed to mean?

*(Music may underscore this scene, which effects the time transition from babyhood to young boyhood. The other purpose of the scene is to show the parents attempting to "protect" their young hemophiliac - - and his energy and zest for living making this clearly impossible.)*

BENJAMIN: I'll show you.

*(He moves to his parents, who are holding the doll, cuddling. He tries to pull the baby away from them so he can explore - - Mother and Father resist, wanting him to stay "safely" with them.)*

MOTHER: You stay with Mommy.

*(He tricks them into releasing the doll, and then manipulates the doll/puppet to show "himself" growing up - - learning to crawl, to stand, to fall (which really worries the parents), to walk. The following lines are interspersed with this movement exploration.)*

MOTHER: Look what he's doing?

FATHER: Hold his hand.

*(He leaps in pure joy and runs!)*

BENJAMIN: Can't catch me.

MOTHER: *(Coaxing him back onto the boat.)* Benjamin. All aboard the Yellow Boat.

*(Benjamin swims to the boat, climbs up and shakes himself off and fishes for a beat or two, then jumps off, swimming again.)*

FATHER: All ashore, who's goin' ashore! Set sail for destinations unknown.

*(Benjamin begins to climb a pole. Then runs to the top of the ramp.)*

BENJAMIN: Mom, Dad, look at me.

MOTHER: We see you!

*(In this moment the actor Benjamin replaces the doll Benjamin - - he is a young boy.)*

FATHER: Good going, partner.

MOTHER: You are getting so big.

BENJAMIN: Let's play . . . on the boat.

*(Music begins again, they all come on board.)*

Come on Dad! Let's explore. All aboard the Yellow Boat. Bound for destinations unknown. Cargo aboard? We each get to take one favorite thing. I'll take a Happy Meal.

FATHER: I'll take a pizza . . .

FATHER and BENJAMIN: With Hollandaise sauce.

MOTHER: I'll just take both of you . . . .

*(Benjamin and Father indicate that this is a joke choice)*

. . . and a bunch of white and yellow daisies.

BENJAMIN: That's where we'll go. To Flower Island! Hoist the sails!

FATHER and MOTHER: Aye, aye, Captain.

BENJAMIN: Hoist the anchor!

FATHER and MOTHER: Aye, Aye, Captain.

BENJAMIN: Set sail for Flower Island.  
Okay, we're there.  
The best flowers are always found at the top of Glacier Mountain, so that's where I'll go.  
*(He shimmies up a pole, and falls.)*

FATHER: Are you alright?

MOTHER: I think it's swelling.

BENJAMIN: Darn. I think I need a shot! Just when Tyrannosaurus Rex was gonna attack us.

FATHER: Tell T. Rex to take a coffee break, and we'll get back to him later. Deal?

BENJAMIN: Deal.

MOTHER and FATHER: Hospital time.

*(They move to the hospital and the infusion procedure is set up.)*

BENJAMIN: It hurts, but I don't cry. Much.

*(The infusion procedure is set up by the doctors and nurses. It takes numerous attempts before they are successful. Doctor #2 attempts a "poke.")*

Owwwww!

FATHER: Easy partner . . .

DOCTOR #2: *(To Benjamin)* Now remember, watch this tube. When it fills with blood we'll stop all this poking! *(Poke.)*

BENJAMIN: Owwwww!

FATHER: *(Giving him crayons, as a diversion.)* Look! Crayons!

DOCTOR #2: *(To Benjamin)* When you see the tube red, we . . .

BENJAMIN: I'll color it red!

*(They divert him.)*

FATHER: Look, draw here on this paper . . .

MOTHER: Use the red crayon, color what you feel!

BENJAMIN: *(He begins to use the crayon as a vehicle for "escape.")*  
Red! Red . . . ? Red . . . !

DOCTOR #2: One more try.

*(Poke.)*

BENJAMIN: Owwww!

MOTHER: Benjamin, use the red crayon; color it out.

DOCTOR #2: Hold real still . . .

BENJAMIN: Just do it! The red train is waiting for the signal.

FATHER: What's the signal, partner?

BENJAMIN: "Poke." That's the signal.

ALL: Poke, poke, poke!

DOCTOR #2: Bull's eye!

*(With the "bulls-eye!", Benjamin pulls away from the infusion action and launches into the story, drawing it three-dimensionally in the space around the continuing infusion scene.)*

BENJAMIN: Red. Train! Color it in. Takes the factor way inside to my knee. Factor Eight! Looks like . . . bathtub plugs! The Red Train picks up speed, climbs all the way to my knee. Then . . . all the bathtub plugs spill out, and that stops the bleeding! *(He "signs" his name at the bottom of the drawing, and then moves back into the infusion scene.)* Ben . . . ja . . . min. Ta da! The End. Now that's a good drawing!

*(The infusion ends.)*

DOCTOR #2: Good job, partner. You held still just the way you should.

BENJAMIN: I know. But next time you should do better than four pokes!

*(The Doctor gives him a big sucker, and the medical staff exit.)*

BENJAMIN: Let's go back to the glacier and look for some jewels.

MOTHER: Let's go back and look for some bed.

BENJAMIN: Awww Mom . . .

FATHER: *(Imitating . . .)* Awww Mom . . . Okay, three seconds of sulk time.

*(They all sulk while Dad counts to three.)*

Now, time for bed. No ifs, ands or buts.

BENJAMIN: You said "BUTT". You're not supposed to say "BUTT," huh Mom? You said so.

FATHER: Then how about keister? And how about bed?

ALL THREE: And brush your teeth.

*(He races off.)*

MOTHER: Slow down. Take it easy on that knee.

BENJAMIN: Can I have a glass of water?

MOTHER: Time for bed.

BENJAMIN: Time . . . for a story?

FATHER: Time for bed.

BENJAMIN: I won't be able to sleep if I don't know how the story ends.

FATHER: Okay. You want to know how the rest goes, right?

BENJAMIN: Right. After we fall off the cliff and are hanging by our ankles from the bungee cords . . .

FATHER: Well. The ropes stretch and stretch, like . . .

FATHER and BENJAMIN: . . . limp spaghetti!

BENJAMIN: And we fall into a giant vat of poison!

FATHER: Nooo. We fall into a giant, soft, feather bed . . .

MOTHER: . . . and drift slowly off to sleep . . .

*(Mother and Father, thinking they are finished, turn to exit.)*

BENJAMIN: That's against the rules!

FATHER: What rules?

BENJAMIN: The rules! If you start a story on the Yellow Boat, you have to finish it on the Yellow Boat!

MOTHER: Are you sure?

BENJAMIN: I made them up!

FATHER: I forgot, I forgot. So sue me! Okay. We roll off the feather bed . . .

BENJAMIN: Into a giant vat of acid!!!

FATHER: Rule number two. Don't interrupt! We roll off the bed, down the hill, and onto our boats. I'm blue . . .

MOTHER: I'm yellow, you're red . . .

BENJAMIN: Nuh, uh. I'm yellow.

FATHER: You sure?

BENJAMIN: I'm sure. I'm the Yellow Boat.

FATHER: *(Revising.)* Okay. So the blue one sails back . . .

MOTHER: And the red one sails back . . .

BENJAMIN: But the Yellow Boat sails up . . .

MOTHER and BENJAMIN: Up . . .

MOTHER and FATHER and BENJAMIN: Up . . . to the Sun!

BENJAMIN: That was awfully short!

FATHER: I know. But Union Story Time is over, and that's all you get in the off hours!

MOTHER: Good night!

BENJAMIN: Time for a hug?

*(As they hug together.)*

MOTHER and FATHER: Love you.

BENJAMIN: Love you too. But tomorrow can I play with some kids?

MOTHER and FATHER: We'll see.

BENJAMIN: Does that mean no?

FATHER: It means we'll see.

BENJAMIN: Next day!

ALL KIDS: Tag!

KID #1: *(Tagging Kid #3)* You're it!

*(A game of tag erupts. Mother hovers protectively near Benjamin. The game swirls around them, until everyone has been "it" except Benjamin. He is tagged.)*

MOTHER: Oh Benjamin, be careful!

*(Benjamin tags Mother and runs away to join the other*

*kids. Mother runs after the kids, tags one, and the game continues until Benjamin is tagged again.)*

BENJAMIN: Pig-Pile!!!

*(A pile-up of all the kids with Benjamin at the bottom. The worried parents make their way towards the pile and pull the kid bodies off of what they are sure is a smashed and bleeding child.)*

MOTHER: Are you all right?

BENJAMIN: I'm fine!

MOTHER: Promise me you'll be more careful . . .

BENJAMIN: Mom. I won!

*(Benjamin returns to the group to continue playing a king of the mountain game.)*

FATHER: I think it's time for school.

MOTHER: Is he ready?

FATHER: Look at him.

MOTHER: *(She can't bear to watch his rough housing.)* Are we ready?

FATHER: Hang in there, Mom. We'll find the right school.

MOTHER: Where? How?

FATHER: Hey, this is America. We shop!

*(The chorus quickly set up "options" for the family to choose.)*

BENJAMIN: Mom, Dad? Come on over here.

*(Coach #2 enters with "students," using his whistle*

*often, to put the kids through their paces. The first whistle, they snap to attention, at the second whistle, they begin to sprint in place. Kids #1 and #4 are clearly the best jocks; #3 and Benjamin have more of a struggle to keep up.)*

COACH #1: Sports! That's what's important. Competition. Challenge. Be the best, the best!

#2 and #3 Whoof, Whoof, Whoof, Whoof.

COACH #1: *(He whistles again, they stop running, Second whistle, they start jumping jacks.)* Firm body, firm mind.

MOTHER: Our son has hemophilia so he may need to take it a little easy on some things.

*(He whistles them to a stop, then on the second whistle, they begin toe touches.)*

COACH #1: He is kind of puny, isn't he? Don't worry about a thing; few months on the field? We'll work out that "hemo" thing.

FATHER: Thanks. But no thanks.

COACH #1: Okay, one more lap . . . *(Whistle)* . . . move it, move it, move it!

*(They all jog off, and transform into another school: the Montessori School from Hell.)*

BENJAMIN: Here!

TEACHER #3: *(The children run amuck.)* We have no rules. We need no rules. Children should be free. Free to explore, free to find their own limits. Our job is to gently remind them of . . . consequences. Excuse me.

*(During her speech, her shoelaces have been tied together, and Jessica #4 has started to pound on an imaginary Aaron. The other kids gather around the*



body. Teacher #3 hops over to Jessica and grabs her.)

TEACHER #3: Jessica, put down that crowbar, and why don't you think about how Aaron might be feeling right now . . .

MOTHER and FATHER: Keep looking. *(They move to another area.)*

BENJAMIN: Mom, Dad! Over here.

*(Teacher #2 and Kids #1, #3, #4, and Eddy #1 enter with "Me dolls" and create another school scene. The parents meet Teacher #2 and he introduces the parents and Benjamin to the class. The parents stay to watch the class as Benjamin joins in.)*

TEACHER: Come and join us. Class, this is Benjamin.

*(The kids immediately "react" to the newcomer, checking him out. The teacher sees this and adopts a strategy to help break the ice.)*

Today's assignment is "Me drawings"

KID #3: What's that?

TEACHER #2: Drawings of You.

EDDY #1: Of Me?

TEACHER: *(Pointing to each kid, and including Benjamin.)* Yes. You. And you, and you . . .

KIDS #1, #2, #4, BENJAMIN: And you and you and you! Me drawings!

KID #2: I'm brown.

KID #3: I'm pink.

BENJAMIN: I'm yellow.

EDDY: I'm green.

KID #4: Yucko.

BENJAMIN: No, that's cool.

KID #4: It is? Oh.

*(The kids draw about themselves, using soft dolls that can "become" them in the later community rejection scene.)*

BENJAMIN: Any shape we want?

TEACHER: Any shape you are.

EDDY: Any color we like?

TEACHER: Any color you feel.

BENJAMIN: I feel purple. I see red. I hear blue. I taste green. I am . . . having a good time here. Mom, Dad? *(Shows them his drawing.)* You can go, now.

*(Mom and Dad leave scene area.)*

TEACHER: Benjamin, will you share your drawing with us?

BENJAMIN: This is my blue stomach, and my checkerboard high tops, and my yellow hat, and these are my bones, and they're dancing inside my body.

KID #4: Gross.

EDDY: Cool!

BENJAMIN: And this is my knee where I had a bleed, and...

KID #3: I don't see any blood.

BENJAMIN: No, it's on the inside. See, it bleeds on the inside, here and here, and gets all red and hot and squishy . . .

KID #4: Gross.

EDDY: Cool!

BENJAMIN: Then I go to the doctor.

TEACHER: What happens at the doctor, Benjamin?

BENJAMIN: I get a shot of Factor 8, and the bleed stops, and then I get a sucker.

EDDY, Kid #3, Kid #4: *(The kids voice approval, and freeze.)* Yeah!

FATHER: *(To teacher)* His hemophilia isn't a problem for you?

TEACHER: Problem? It's an opportunity. Welcome to our community.

*(Adults exit. Time Shift. Playtime.)*

BENJAMIN, EDDY, KID #3, KID #4: Recess!

KID #3: So what do you want to do?

KID #4: I don't know, what do you want to do?

KID #3: I don't know.

BENJAMIN: I have an idea. We can go on the Yellow Boat. C'mon Eddy.

KID #4: Boats are boring.

BENJAMIN: This is a Yellow Boat!

EDDY: And it can fly!

KID #4: Really?

EDDY: Really.

KID #4: Cool.

BENJAMIN: Here, I'll draw it for you.

KID #4: Drawing? Drawing's boring.

BENJAMIN: Not this way. I'll draw it so you can do it! C'mon aboard. Here's the deck, and here's the mast.

*(#1 has become a kid, and he is hiding, waiting to be pulled up into the action of Benjamin 's story. He becomes the mast.)*

Load cargo, now.

*(Benjamin continues drawing as the kids begin to do so.)*

KID #3: Are we going or what?

*(Music begins to support this change to fantasy storytelling.)*

BENJAMIN: Okay, hoist the sails, hoist the anchor. You're supposed to say: "Aye, aye, Captain."

ALL THE KIDS: Aye, aye, Captain! *(They begin to sail.)*

KID #3: Can I steer?

BENJAMIN: Nope, only the Captain gets to steer. I stand right here and draw, and steer.

KID #3: I want to be captain!

BENJAMIN: Then draw your own boat.

KID #3: I can't draw as good as you!

BENJAMIN: I know. You can be helper. She gets to steer if the Captain gets tired.

KID #3: Does that ever happen?

BENJAMIN: Nope.

*(Music changes to indicate approaching storm.)*

KID #1: Storm up ahead!

BENJAMIN: We can fly! Start special hydraulic-powered flyers.

*(Benjamin draws as kids become a flying Yellow Boat, complete with sound effects. They begin to fly, Kid #3 grabs the crayon from Benjamin and draws in the air.)*

KID #3: Land ho.

BENJAMIN: How do you know?

KID #3: I just drew it!

BENJAMIN: I'm the captain!

EDDY: Don't be so bossy.

BENJAMIN: I'm not. Land ho!

KID #4: Where are we?

BENJAMIN: Ask her. She's drawing it.

*(The scene shifts to a Fantasy Island.)*

KID #3: Uh, it's an island. There are palm trees, and monkeys.

*(Benjamin climbs a pole as a monkey, but falls.)*

EDDY: Benjamin, you all right?

BENJAMIN: I'm fine.

*(They continue.)*

KID #3: And there's a cave there.

*(#2 and #4 make a cave as she draws it.)*

It's the home of . . . a king? A Giant King of the . . .  
*(Searching for a name.)*

BENJAMIN: Svengalese.

KID #3: Yeah! The Giant King of the Svengalese.

*(When the kids look up, they see that #2 and #4 have transformed themselves into the King, and he is indeed, evil and vicious. A little too so!)*

BENJAMIN: No, not the Giant King. Erasers!

*(They all erase it as the Giant falls apart and reforms.)*

*(To Kid #3) You have to be careful around here.*

*(He takes the crayon and continues. He whispers with Eddy, and Eddy's finger becomes the midgetized king. They have played this game before, and Benjamin is clearly the director.)*

Now, we have stumbled upon the magical castle of the teeny-tiny midgetized King of the Svengalese.

*(Eddy slowly reveals his index finger with crown and grass skirt: The King.)*

He's friendly. He speaks in Svengalese. Luckily, I know it.

EDDY-KING: *(10 seconds of gibberish.)*

KID #3: What did he say?

BENJAMIN: Hello.

EDDY-KING: *(Gibberish)*

BENJAMIN: "You strangers are welcome here, and have come just in time."

KING: *(Gibberish, is overlapped with translation.)*

KID #4: Why just in time?

BENJAMIN: Why just in time?

*(Eddy/King pantomimes a volcano erupting, and then Benjamin communicates the emergency.)*

The volcano is erupting, and you must save my people. Quick, take us on your boat, and let's get out of here!

*(Benjamin draws #1 into The Erupting Volcano as kids run around in terror.)*

EDDY: How do we save all the Svengalese?

BENJAMIN: Erase the volcano.

*(They do, and the Volcano melts, turning back into Eddy.)*

Draw more boats.

*(Kids sail away, saving the Svengalese.)*

BENJAMIN: Land ho!

EDDY: Safe!

*(The Boat vanishes as the game ends.)*

KID #4: That was fun. Let's do it again tomorrow.

EDDY: I think she likes you.

BENJAMIN: Yuck.

*(The kids exit and Benjamin takes out a huge piece of paper to make a new drawing. The previous play has triggered a bleed, but drawing a new adventure is more important than that right now.)*

This is going to be a big one. This is a map to help the Svengalese, and their friendly King know where to find . . . their Enemy! That Big Guy.

*(Mother enters.)*

MOTHER: What are you doing?

BENJAMIN: I'm drawing. His castle sits high on top of a cliff, so to get there, first you have to climb all these ladders of . . . bones. Cat bones . . . yea!

*(As he draws, he enters into the action of his picture enough so that Mother notices that he is limping slightly.)*

MOTHER: How's your knee?

BENJAMIN: Oh . . . fine. The Big Guy's hiding way up here, in this tower . . .

*(As he shows the path that will be taken on the paper, his movement betrays the knee-bleed he's trying to ignore.)*

MOTHER: Are you limping?

BENJAMIN: Mom! Now, the King has to go through these traps and mazes . . .

MOTHER: Let me see it.

*(She examines his knee.)* Can you straighten it?

*(It hurts.)*

BENJAMIN: Mom!

MOTHER: I'll call the hospital.

BENJAMIN: I don't have time for that; I'm working on this map . . .

MOTHER: You can take it along.

BENJAMIN: It's too big for the car! It's a whole castle!!!

MOTHER: Then just take one room.

BENJAMIN: Oh. Okay. I'll take . . . the torture room!

MOTHER: Of course.

BENJAMIN: I'll need lots of red for the blood . . .

*(Mother and Benjamin shift location, and the infusion procedure begins, set up as before. He draws throughout the procedure. During this infusion we see the red "blood" tinged with another colored contaminant: the HIV virus. Benjamin continues his monologue as he draws.)*

BENJAMIN: When you open this door, the skeleton is waiting with buckets of poison . . . lemonade. Drink it, you turn into . . . a ghost! So, don't drink it! But if you step here, you fall through the floor of the torture room. Ahhhhhhhhh. . . Splat!

MOTHER: *(Returning.)* They're all done. You can finish that up at home.

*(They return home. Sound underscores the following. #2, #3, and #4 tear and fold the large piece of drawing paper into "newspapers," or the scene can be staged to include some other medias.)*

BENJAMIN: *(He begins to draw on his "Me Doll.")* New drawing. Benjamin's Body. Everything looks the same. Outside.

*(Chorus [#2, #3, #4] moves and announce the following headlines. There is a sense of this information moving into, invading, the personal space of the family. The parents do not react directly to the announcements, but are affected by their sense.)*

#3: Doctors alarmed by mystery illness.

#4: Disease approaching epidemic proportions.

MOTHER: I've just got this feeling . . .

FATHER: You worry too much.

*(Chorus moves and announces:)*

#2: Immune deficiency linked to infant deaths.

MOTHER: Doctor says his weight is down, and he's a little anemic.

FATHER: Maybe it's a growth spurt?

BENJAMIN: Inside. Almost the same. Except my stomach.

*(Chorus moves and announces:)*

#3: Transmitted by the exchange of body fluids . . .

#2: Rate of infection up among at-risk populations.

FATHER: Maybe it's the flu, everybody in his class has an upset stomach and diarrhea.

MOTHER: But he's had it over a week.

*(Chorus moves and announces:)*

#3: Officials insist blood supply is 100% safe!

#4: 83-year-old Grandmother dies of AIDS?

#2: Cause of infection unknown.

BENJAMIN: And my head turns tired. And my legs turn tired. And my fingers . . . even my drawing is tired.

FATHER: He's going to be all right!

MOTHER: How do you know that?

FATHER: I don't know that. I hope that.

*(Benjamin begins to make "spots" on the "Me Doll," and gradually on himself. The chorus begins a litany of states.)*

#2: Cases of AIDS reported in California.

#4: New York.

#3: Florida.

MOTHER: Something's wrong, I just know it. It's like a spark has gone out of him . . .

#2: Indiana.

MOTHER: Don't you think he should be tested?

#4: Pennsylvania.

#3: Arizona.

FATHER: Tested for what?

#4: Illinois. Michigan.

#3: Texas. Tennessee.

*(Doctor enters.)*

DOCTOR #1: We checked first with the ELISA. . . .

MOTHER: Tested for everything!

DOCTOR #1: . . . and the Western Blot Test.

MOTHER: You know . . . EVERYTHING!

DOCTOR #1: Your son . . . has tested . . . positive for the AIDS virus. I'm very sorry. We'll do everything that we can. *(He exits.)*

MOTHER: I just knew it. What are we going to do?

FATHER: I don't know. We'll . . . just do, I guess.

MOTHER: How do we tell him?

FATHER: The right words will come.

*(The parents move to Benjamin.)*

FATHER: Uh, Benjamin, we need to talk.

BENJAMIN: About what?

MOTHER and FATHER: Well, . . .

MOTHER: Well, about some things that . . . we're thinking about, and . . .

BENJAMIN: About your meeting with the doctor, yesterday?

MOTHER: Yes.

FATHER: You know he's been giving you lots of tests, to see if there's any reason why you've been more tired lately. And one of the tests . . .

MOTHER: He did a couple of special tests. And he found something in your blood that shouldn't be there.

FATHER: A bug; a kind of bug - - a virus.

BENJAMIN: AIDS?

FATHER: How do you know . . . ?

BENJAMIN: TV.

MOTHER: No. Not AIDS. Not AIDS . . . But they found a little bit of the virus that can lead to the disease.

FATHER: They'll do a lot more tests; they want to make you feel better!

BENJAMIN: How did I get it?

FATHER: Some of the blood that makes the factor must have had some of the virus in it.

BENJAMIN: Does everybody who gets a shot get AIDS?

FATHER: No. And not everyone who gets a transfusion will get it.

BENJAMIN: Will I be alright?

FATHER: Yes.

MOTHER: I promise you.

FATHER: We're right here.

*(Benjamin moves away from his parents to assimilate the news.)*

FATHER: We're going to get some answers!

*(The parents move to where Doctor #2 has entered. The following scenes should swirl around the space as the parents try to get some control of the situation.)*

What about this AZT?

DOCTOR #2: It looks promising.

FATHER: When can we start it?

DOCTOR #2: We can't. It's not available for children.

MOTHER: When will it be available?

DOCTOR #2: I don't know.

*(They move away from this Doctor over to where the Healer #4 has entered.)*

MOTHER: Let's just try this.

HEALER #4: Two quarts of clover tea daily, and wear this crystal.

FATHER: Will that help?

HEALER #4: I don't know.

*(They whirl up stage to where Doctor #1 has entered.)*

FATHER: What do we call it?

DOCTOR #1: Well, it's not AIDS.

FATHER: No?

DOCTOR #1: Technically. He has the virus, but none of the diseases that the government posts as markers.

MOTHER: He has the disease? But not the disease.

DOCTOR #1: Technically.

FATHER: Which is it?

MOTHER: Yes or no?

DOCTOR #1: Yes and no.

FATHER: What do we do?

*(The doctors' words swirl around the parents.)*

DOCTOR #1: I don't know . . . appointment, next week; Wednesday, nine-thirty.

DOCTOR #2: I don't know.

HEALER #3: Appointment, Friday at one.

DOCTOR #1: I don't know.

DOCTOR #2: Appointment on Thursday, three o'clock.

HEALER #3: I don't know.

DOCTOR and HEALER: I don't know, I don't know, I don't know . . .

*(This builds to their exit, leaving Mother and Father totally bewildered. Benjamin jumps up.)*

BENJAMIN: Nobody knows anything, except me, and all I know is that no one knows anything!

FATHER: *(To Mother)* It's going to be alright . . . but we're going to need help on this one. We've got a lot of friends.

*(The community parents [#1, #2, #3 and #4] enter, and gather their "children," the Me Dolls that were last seen in the recess scene. They greet Mom and Dad. Benjamin returns to drawing on his Me Doll.)*

FATHER: Thank you all for coming on such short notice. We need to ask for some help. Lots of help, actually.

*(Community response overlaps:)*

#4: Sure, anything.

#1: Anything at all.

#3: Whatever we can do to help, just ask.

#2: Hey, what are friends for?

FATHER: Benjamin has tested . . . positive . . . for the AIDS virus.

*(There is a moment of total silence. Then slightly overlapping response.)*

#1 and #3: Oh.

#4: Sorry.

#2: How did he . . . ?

MOTHER: *(To break the silence.)* There is so much about this that we don't know right now . . .

FATHER: We need your help!

*(Community parents, without wanting to appear so, slowly begin to pull their children away from the family, all the while voicing their support.)*

#3: Sure, anything. Anything at all.

#2: Whatever we can do to help.

#3: Just ask.

FATHER: The best thing we can do is just to keep things as normal as possible.

MOTHER: What he needs, what we need, is to try to have a normal life.

#1: *(Backing away)* Hey, what are friends for?

FATHER: So, how about we take all the kids to Ghostbusters, Friday night?

*(#1 unfurls a large sheet of plastic, which slowly forms a plastic barrier between Benjamin and everyone else. His Me Doll tries to "contact" other Me Dolls through the plastic wall, but their parents pull them away.)*

#4: Anything.

#3: Anything at all.

FATHER: Saturday afternoon?

#1: Anything at all.

FATHER: Sunday?

#1: Anything.

MOTHER: The pool is open, we could take the kids swimming?

#3: Whatever we can do,



#1: . . . just ask.

MOTHER: We're going camping this weekend; how about . . .

#4: Just ask.

#1: Just ask.

MOTHER: A sleep over?

#3: Just ask.

#4: Just ask.

#1: Just ask.

MOTHER: I AM asking!

(Time shift.)

BENJAMIN: Today is my birthday and I'm seven, and I'm having a party.

(Eddy enters with a box wrapped in paper with a long ribbon. He and Benjamin are in separate spaces, divided by the plastic wall.)

EDDY: This is so great. He'll never guess what this is 'til it pops out in his face.

EDDY's MOTHER (#4): Eddy, what are you doing?

EDDY: Finishing up my present for Benjamin. (He tries to tie the bow.)

EDDY's MOTHER: Finish up quickly, and I'll drop it off on my way to the grocery store.

BENJAMIN: I'm having pie instead of cake, 'cause I don't like cake, and it's MY birthday.

EDDY: You can just drop me off for the party . . .

EDDY's MOTHER: I can't do that. I'm sorry Eddy, but you can't go to that party!

EDDY: But he's my best friend.

EDDY's MOTHER: I know this is hard, but . . .

EDDY: But I have to go . . .

EDDY's MOTHER: Don't argue with me! I'll drop the present off this afternoon. I know what's best for you.

(They exit.)

BENJAMIN: No one's coming? Not even Eddy?

(Time shift. Teacher #1 enters.)

TEACHER (#2): The board met last night. I'm afraid Benjamin won't be able to attend school here anymore.

MOTHER: What?

TEACHER: We're just not set up to handle this sort of thing.

FATHER: The doctors are positive that he's safe in school and with some simple precautions, everyone else is safe as well.

TEACHER: The board is comfortable with its decision. He'll have to leave.

MOTHER: When?

TEACHER: Immediately.

MOTHER: Can he stay to the end of the week?

TEACHER: Immediately!

MOTHER: Just another day?

TEACHER: I'll see . . . if I can help you find a tutor . . .

*(He exits. Time shift.)*

BENJAMIN: Why can't I go to school?

MOTHER: I don't know.

BENJAMIN: Why won't anyone come to play with me?

FATHER: We're here to play with you.

MOTHER: What would you like to play?

BENJAMIN: Nothing.

*(He takes out a wide black marker, and slowly draws an outline of himself on the plastic, in silence. As he is doing this body drawing, the parents are isolated in their own spaces, but try to "contact" him, and each other, with the following lines. He shuts them out.)*

MOTHER: Benjamin. Would you like some juice?

FATHER: It's like he's slipped away . . .

MOTHER: How about a sandwich?

FATHER: Or a Happy Meal. You've got to eat something, so you can get better.

MOTHER: Slipped away. On his own boat . . . on his own sea.

FATHER: He doesn't speak. He doesn't eat.

MOTHER: Benjamin?

FATHER: He spends day after day curled up on the sofa . . .

MOTHER: Just picking his arm.

FATHER: Benjamin.

MOTHER: Picking. Like a little monkey.

FATHER: Benjamin.

MOTHER: Benjamin.

*(Benjamin crosses out his image. He drops the marker. He has stopped drawing. Doctor #2 enters.)*

DOCTOR #1: His white blood count is dangerously low. We need to admit him to the hospital immediately.

*(The scene shifts to the hospital. The sound support for the hospital should be constant; hum, buzz, beep, at varying volumes for each scene. It can also be used to help mark time shifts. By adding a sheet and pillow, the boat becomes a hospital bed. Benjamin is given a hospital gown, and moved to the bed. The parents move through long hallways, answering questions.)*

DOCTOR #4: Name?

FATHER: Benjamin.

DOCTOR #4: Spell that please.

FATHER: B-E-N-J-A-M-I-N.

DOCTOR #4: Number?

FATHER: 516-43-8645

DOCTOR #2: Name?

MOTHER: Benjamin.

DOCTOR #2: Spell that please.

MOTHER: B-E-N-J-A-M-I-N.

DOCTOR #2: Number?

MOTHER: 516-43-8645.

DOCTOR #1: Name?

MOTHER and FATHER: Benjamin.

DOCTOR #1: Spell that please.

MOTHER and FATHER: B-E-N-J-A-M-I-N.

DOCTOR #1: Number?

MOTHER and FATHER: 516-43-8645.

*(As Benjamin is put in the bed, doctors repeat these requests. Mother and Father continue to answer, and then stop. Benjamin, in the bed, looks around, and registers with a look that he feels completely alone. Silence for a beat.)*

*(Joy [#3] enters, carrying her backpack. As soon as he hears her approach he turns away. She pulls a kazoo out and tootles a greeting. There is no response. She tries again; no response. She tootles "bye, bye." and then leaves the kazoo near his feet at the end of the bed. Joy exits, but watches for a moment in the doorway. Benjamin is tempted to check out what she has left, but just as he is reaching for it, three doctors enter.)*

DOCTOR #2: Good morning.

DOCTOR #4: . . . afternoon.

DOCTOR #1: . . . evening.

ALL DOCTORS: And how are we feeling today? Hmmmm?

*(Short pause for response.)*

DOCTOR #2: Patient . . .

DOCTOR #4: Not responding.

DOCTOR #1: Check.

DOCTOR #2: Vital signs, Q-2 times 4.

DOCTOR #4: Check.

FATHER: It's like another country.

MOTHER: White walls, white floors, white sound . . .

DOCTOR #2: NPO, 48 hours.

DOCTOR #1: Charted.

DOCTOR #4: Check.

*(The doctors retreat; as they exit one removes the kazoo as if it had no place here.)*

FATHER: Stainless steel, hard edges . . .

MOTHER: Not a single soft thing in this whole place.

*(The parents move toward the room, but are intercepted by the swoop of the doctors.)*

DOCTOR #2: Caution! Blood Precautions!

DOCTOR #4: Oxygen in use!

DOCTOR #1: Gowns, masks, gloves suggested!

MOTHER: I'm his Mother!

*(All doctors snap on their gloves.)*

MOTHER: I hate that sound! Benjamin . . .

*(Time Shift. The parents and doctors move to the bed. One doctor has a length of plastic tubing for a medical test.)*

DOCTOR #2: We'll need samples,  
 DOCTOR #4: . . . specimens,  
 DOCTOR #1: . . . statistics!  
 ALL DOCTORS: Check!

MOTHER: Benjamin, these doctors need to do some tests . . .  
*(Benjamin turns away, shutting them all out.)*

FATHER: Help us with this . . . they need you to swallow this little plastic tube . . .

DOCTOR #1: We need a sample . . .

FATHER: We need your help, sport . . .

DOCTOR #2: Please cough,  
 DOCTOR #4: Open your mouth,  
 DOCTOR #1: Just relax . . .

ALL DOCTORS: Breathe.

DOCTOR #2: Cough.

DOCTOR #4: Open.

DOCTOR #1: Relax.

ALL DOCTORS: Breathe.

DOCTOR #2: Cough.

DOCTOR #4: Open.

DOCTOR #1: Relax.

ALL DOCTORS: Breathe.

BENJAMIN: Leave me alone. Just leave me alone!

DOCTOR #2: Please step out into the hall?  
*(Parents and Doctor #2 move to one side. Doctors #1 and #4 move away, consulting their charts.)*

DOCTOR #2: We're doing our best. He's maintaining . . .

DOCTOR #4: maintaining . . .

DOCTOR #1: maintaining . . .

FATHER: Tell me what we're fighting? AIDS, depression, what?

DOCTOR #2: All of it.

DOCTORS #1 & #4: All of it.

*(Doctors move away and continue to consult their charts and each other. Mother and Father stay to the side as Joy approaches the room a second time. She is wearing a necklace of whistles and kazoos.)*

JOY: *(She tootles him a "hello" on several different whistles and/or kazoos. Benjamin "shuts her out", both physically and with an angry sound.)*

Okay, okay. I'll come back later.

*(Takes three steps away, and returns. Kazoo flourish.)*

It's later.

*(He turns his back to her.)*

Tell you what. Whenever you want me to disappear, just flick your hand, like this. *(She demonstrates with small hand flick of dismissal.)* I'm gone. History.

*(Benjamin flicks his hand. She withdraws. Then returns.)*

JOY: I'm back.  
*(Benjamin flicks his hand. )*  
 I'm gone.  
*(Kazoo "good-bye." She exits.)*  
*(Time shift. Three doctors enter to bedside.)*

DOCTOR #2: Good morning.

DOCTOR #3: . . . afternoon.

DOCTOR #1: . . . evening.

ALL DOCTORS: And how are we feeling today? Hmmmm?

*(Doctor #1 goes to parents. Doctors #2 and #3 repeat the following lines, but become increasingly more "human" in their delivery; a "time shift" that indicates a change in attitude towards this patient.)*

DOCTOR #2 and #3: And how are we feeling today? Hmmmm? And how are we feeling today? Hmmmm?

MOTHER: Why is nothing working? You keep testing and poking and prodding; there's no change.

FATHER: He's pulling further and further away.

DOCTOR #1: We're doing everything we know. Everything we can . . . We'll keep trying! *(He moves to join the other doctors.)*  
*(To other doctors as they exit.)* Let's take another look at those X-rays.  
*(Joy moves to parents.)*

JOY: Hi. I'm Joy, the Child Life Specialist on this wing.

MOTHER: Another doctor?

JOY: Not exactly. The doctors work with the sick parts; my specialty is the well parts.

FATHER: What?

JOY: My work is play.

FATHER: There's not much of that around here.

JOY: I'll try to change that. I'm here to work with Benjamin to try to make some sense out of this place.

FATHER: Good luck!

MOTHER: He won't eat, he won't talk . . . He won't even draw.

JOY: Is that something he likes to do? Drawing?

MOTHER: He used to draw all the time.

FATHER: He's just not Benjamin if he's not drawing.

JOY: That's good to know. Why don't you two get a cup of coffee?

MOTHER: We should stay . . .

JOY: *(She pulls a crayon from her pack.)* Just let me have a look for a well part.

FATHER: Come on.  
*(They exit. Joy approaches Benjamin.)*

JOY: *(She enters, heralding her arrival on a slide whistle. He flicks his hand to dismiss her. She withdraws then returns, this time with a train whistle. He flicks her away. She withdraws then returns with a duck call. Benjamin almost flicks. Then changes his mind. There is a moment of "small victory" for Joy.)*  
 You don't need to talk. I can just sit here with you.

JOY: *(She sits, and pulls a small cloth doll and set of markers out of her backpack.)* I have some work to do. I want to make this doll for a boy here in the hospital. He hates being here, what with the shots and the medicines . . . ? But this doll needs a name . . . Can you think of a good name?

BENJAMIN: No.

JOY: No is an excellent name! Now, No has to have a lot of tests, and maybe even an operation. Can you tell him anything he needs to know?

BENJAMIN: No.

JOY: Okay. But No needs some hair, what color should it be?

*(No response.)*

Brown? Nah. Purple!

*(This odd choice tweaks just the smallest bit of interest in Benjamin. He watches as Joy colors the hair.)*

How about his eyes?

*(She holds out some crayons between she and Benjamin, and after some hesitation, Benjamin chooses an orange one.)*

Orange.

BENJAMIN: Except when he cries. His tears are red.

JOY: Red tears . . . ! And his mouth?

*(She colors as he chooses.)*

BENJAMIN: Mad green.

JOY: And his eye brows are . . . ?

BENJAMIN: Yellow. Scared yellow.

JOY: So, his mouth is mad, and his eyes are scared, and his red tears are so very sad. And he feels . . . ?

BENJAMIN: Alone.

JOY: Isn't it amazing how you can have so many people in and out of here, and still feel so all alone? *(She finished up the coloring.)* TAHDAH!! *(Or the kazoo equivalent)*

*(Benjamin looks over at the drawing on the doll, and makes a sound of some disapproval . . . )*

BENJAMIN: EEUUuwww!

JOY: So I'm not good at faces . . . you want to try?

BENJAMIN: No. *(He turns away again.)*

JOY: Okay. I have to go. Maybe No can come back tomorrow?

*(He shrugs "Maybe . . ." She leaves the whistle necklace on his bed and exits.)*

*(Time shift.)*

BENJAMIN: *(Remembering, and punctuating the speech with various whistles.)* And she comes back tomorrow. And the next tomorrow. And the next. She lets me talk when I want to, and she doesn't make me say "I'm fine" if I don't feel like it. She tells me about hospital things, so I know what's going on . . .

*(Time shift. Doctor #1 is speaking to the parents.)*

DOCTOR #1: I've ordered up an endoscopy . . . a stomach test. We'll set it up for the morning.

*(Joy enters, with an armful of medical equipment: an endoscope, plastic tubing, a flash light, an elastic string,*

*a No doll with surgical mask and cap. As part of her set-up, she presents each piece to Benjamin without directly doing so. He watches, but doesn't want to be seen doing so. The parents also enter, and Joy involves them in her Magical Medical Circus. She introduces the event with a kazoo fanfare.)*

JOY:

Good evening ladies and gentlemen, and welcome to the Magical Medical Circus - - a really big show in a really small space, hastily assembled for you today. Thank-you. Featuring No, the daredevil artiste! He's here to show you how a stomach test works. Thank-you, No. He will use this . . . *(She shows the elastic string.)* . . . and this . . . *(She pulls out a flashlight and beckons to Mother. Speaking as NO.)* Hey, pretty lady, come over here.

*(Mother comes over and No hands her a flash light.)*

*(As No.)* Thank you. *(As Joy.)* And he will use this.

*(She presents the endoscope. At this scary sight Benjamin turns away, but Joy quickly wins him back with NO.)*

Quiet please, the artiste prepares. *(She puts No through traditional actor warm-up techniques, then explains the procedure in circus terms.)* He's going to fly up to a highwire stretched from here . . . *(She stretches an elastic string over Benjamin.)* . . . to . . . here. Could you hold this, please?

*(She offers it to Benjamin, who finally decides to take it. He holds it in the air, making a tightrope line for No.)*

Thanks! *(As No.)* It's time for Stomach Bungee jumping! I will descend to your stomach, fetch a sample with this . . . *(Showing him the light and tube at the end of the scope.)* . . . and then "sproing" back to my starting position, unscathed, untouched, unharmed. Watch!

*(No is unable to jump all the way up to the elastic line*

*with the weight of the scope, so after a few attempts, he gets an idea:)*

JOY:

AAHhhh, wait. *(Joy blows up a rubber glove like a balloon and attaches it to No.)*

*(As No.)* Lights!

*(Mom turns on the flash light as a follow spot.)*

*(As No.)* Drum roll, please!

*(Dad does, at the foot of the bed. No floats up to the elastic wire, walks down the wire, and prepares to descend:)*

*(As No.)* Attach bungee! Uno, Duo, Tre . . . BUNGEEEE!

*(NO, with elastic end at his foot, descends to Benjamin's stomach, and bounces back up.)*

*(As No.)* Safe! Stomach test complete!

*(Benjamin lets the line snap free, so No crashes to the floor.)*

Thank you No!

*(The parents clap then exit.)*

BENJAMIN: What's No going to do with it?

JOY: With what?

BENJAMIN: With that stomach stuff.

JOY: The doctors need to look at it.

BENJAMIN: Yuck.

JOY: So they can figure out the right medicines.

BENJAMIN: Will it hurt?

JOY: Just 'til No stops bouncing. So. Are you ready to help them?

BENJAMIN: Maybe . . .

*(He holds out his hand for her to shake; when she tries to do so he fakes her out, and quite enjoys his little victory. She exits.)*

*(Time shift.)*

*(Remembering.)* Then one night, as a surprise, she sticks glow-in-the-dark stars on the ceiling over my bed, and another day, she paints a picture right on my window, so when the sun shines through it in the afternoon, it turns the white wall into colors.

*(Time shift. Mother enters to tuck him in, and Eddy enters.)*

MOTHER: Benjamin? Look who's here.

BENJAMIN: Eddy!!!

*(They both silently indicate to Mom that they'd like her to leave.)*

MOTHER: I'll leave you two alone. *(She exits. There is an awkward silence.)*

BENJAMIN: Eddy . . .

EDDY: *(Indicating the bed control panel.)* So. What's all this stuff?

BENJAMIN: This is my remote control for my very own TV, and this makes my bed go up and down . . .

EDDY: Cool.

BENJAMIN: And see this tube stuck in my chest?

EDDY: Wooah!

BENJAMIN: It's for medicine, so the doctors don't have to keep giving me shots. If I had a couple of bolts, I'd look just like Frankenstein.

EDDY: I could bring you some.

BENJAMIN: Some what?

EDDY: Some Frankenstein bolts.

BENJAMIN: Could you?

EDDY: They stick right to your head.

BENJAMIN: No way!

EDDY: Way!

BENJAMIN: That'd really surprise the doctors.

EDDY: Yeah! So what's it like to be in here?

BENJAMIN: It's okay. But they never leave you alone.

EDDY: Like my Mom?

BENJAMIN: Worse than your Mom.

EDDY: Oh, no! Does it hurt?

BENJAMIN: Yeah.

EDDY: Do you cry?

BENJAMIN: No. Sometimes.

EDDY: Yeah.



BENJAMIN: Were you scared to come see me?

EDDY: No. A little.

BENJAMIN: Why? I'm just me.

EDDY: Yeah, but I never knew anyone, who . . . you know . . .

BENJAMIN: Was sick . . . ? Had AIDS?

EDDY: Yeah.

BENJAMIN: You can't catch it just by sitting next to me. It's not like cooties.

EDDY: I know that. I didn't know if you'd be mad at me.

BENJAMIN: Why didn't you come to my birthday?

EDDY: My Mom said no.

BENJAMIN: So why'd she let you come now?

EDDY: I dunno. She read a bunch of stuff, we all talked about it, and she changed her mind. You want to draw or something?

BENJAMIN: I'm a little tired . . .

EDDY: I'd better go then; they said I shouldn't stay too long.

BENJAMIN: I'm glad you came.

EDDY: Yeah.

BENJAMIN: Will you come back?

EDDY: I said I'd bring the bolts, didn't I?

*(They high five, Eddy exits.)*

*(Time shift. Joy and Doctor #2 enter. Joy carries an*

*X-Ray, and backpack, the Doctor consults his chart.)*

JOY: Good morning . . . ,

BENJAMIN: . . . afternoon,

DOCTOR #4: Evening!

JOY: And how are we feeling today...

BENJAMIN, JOY and DOCTOR #4: Hmmmmmm???

BENJAMIN: Eddy came to visit!

JOY: How did it go?

BENJAMIN: He's still my best friend. And he's bringing me . . . it's a surprise.

JOY: Did you have a good night?

BENJAMIN: No . . .

JOY: What happened?

BENJAMIN: More bleeding.

DOCTOR #4: That explains this new plan.

BENJAMIN: More tests?

DOCTOR #4: We're going to do an exploratory surgery, so we can take a look at what's going on in there.

BENJAMIN: I'm tired of all the looking; I'm ready for some finding.

JOY: They'll have an easier time if you'll help them.

BENJAMIN: What else are they going to do to me?

JOY: Remember when you drank that Barium stuff yesterday?

BENJAMIN: Yuck!!!

JOY: And they took an X-Ray of your insides? Well here it is!  
(*She shows him an X-Ray film.*)

BENJAMIN: (*Examining the picture.*) That's me?

JOY: Yep.

BENJAMIN: Inside?

JOY: Yep.

BENJAMIN: Well that's a pretty crummy picture. It's all gray. Gray is not what it feels like.

DOCTOR #4: Then how does it feel?

BENJAMIN: Not gray.

JOY: Tell me.

BENJAMIN: This, down here . . . ? (*Indicating stomach.*) It feels . . . it feels like . . . I can't tell you . . .

JOY: Keep trying . . .

BENJAMIN: When it hurts the worst, like last night? It's like . . . like slow red spikes of hurt . . . (*Indicating on himself.*) Here and here.

JOY: (*Indicating the X-Ray, then his stomach.*) This part here, is a picture of that part there.

BENJAMIN: Well it's not the right colors.

JOY: (*Holding out the crayons.*) You want to make it the right colors?

BENJAMIN: (*Tempted but not buying it yet.*) No. You can.

JOY: Okay, but you have to tell me how.

BENJAMIN: (*He indicates on himself. She colors the X-Ray.*) This is blue. It's fine, but orange is getting closer . . . burning orange. And farther down, that's where it really hurts; sharp pains like . . . pins dripping acid, purple and green. That's where it's dark, hurting, red. Red. Red. RED!!!

(*The coloring is interrupted by the entrance of Doctors #1 & #2.*)

DOCTOR #1: Good morning . . .

DOCTOR #2: . . . afternoon . . .

DOCTOR #1: . . . evening . . .

DOCTOR S #1 & #2: And how are we feeling today, hmmm?

BENJAMIN: Red.

DOCTOR #1: I beg your pardon?

JOY: He feels red.

Doctor #1: That's nice . . .

BENJAMIN: And here is black-and-blue, where he poked me yesterday.

DOCTOR #2: I needed those samples to help us prepare for exploratory surgery.

BENJAMIN: You're an explorer?

DOCTOR #2: Well, I guess so . . .

DOCTOR #4: We're exploring ways to make you feel better.

BENJAMIN: You're awfully white. Why so white?

DOCTOR #1: Doctors always wear white.

BENJAMIN: Explorers don't wear white. White's boring.

JOY: Benjamin, why don't you tell the doctors about the pain?

BENJAMIN: I can't.

DOCTOR #4: It would help us if you could.

BENJAMIN: It hurts all over.

DOCTOR #1: Where?

BENJAMIN: Some places more than others.

DOCTOR #2: When?

BENJAMIN: Sometimes, all the time, I don't know . . .

DOCTOR #1: How?

BENJAMIN: It doesn't have words, it just feels! I can't tell them!

JOY: You could show them. *(Holding out the X-Ray film.)* This could be a map. Color it to help them find the hurt!

*(She holds out a crayon. Benjamin hesitates for a moment, then seizes it.)*

BENJAMIN: A map? *(He takes the X-Ray from her.)* I'm good at maps. New Drawing!

*(Everybody freezes in position as Benjamin takes up the crayon and holds it aloft.)*

Journey to the Center of My Guts!

*(The Doctors and Joy are transformed into a small band of explorers, checking supplies prior to departure on an expedition.)*

JOY: Equipment check. What do we need?

DOCTOR #2: Antibiotic.

DOCTOR #4: Hypodermic.

DOCTOR #1: Antiseptic.

BENJAMIN: Ick. Get Well Medicine. And a bazooka!

ALL DOCTORS: Bazooka?

JOY: Bazooka!

BENJAMIN: Command Central over to Field Team One. Do you read me?

JOY: Roger, Captain. How do we get in?

BENJAMIN: Through my mouth. I'll leave it open so you can see better.

*(Benjamin draws his mouth with big circles, as the doctors climb over the boat, starting into his body. The progress through the body should be supported with as much movement, lighting and sound support as can be mustered.)*

First stop? My lungs.

*(They enter a whoosh world.)*

Air world, feels blue . . .

DOCTOR #4: This side is clear. No problems. Let's check the other lobe . . .

BENJAMIN: Here grayer, tighter . . .

DOCTOR #4: Definite congestion. I'll order up respiratory therapy.

BENJAMIN: Now find the hurt. Into the blood.

*(They are swept along through the bloodstream.)*

In one side of my heart. It's blue, 'cause I've got a strong heart - - and out the other.

DOCTOR #2: Past the liver . . .

BENJAMIN: Gross. I hate liver, it's green! Be careful.

JOY: Where are we?

BENJAMIN: In my guts. That's where it hurts.

DOCTOR #1: Looks like the small intestine.

BENJAMIN: Entering danger zone. But you're not there yet, keep going . . .

DOCTOR #1: Farther?

BENJAMIN: Farther. Go farther. Feel the fire . . .

DOCTOR #2: Signs of infection ahead . . .

BENJAMIN: Dark red!  
Scorch arrows. Shooting fire.

*(The attack begins. Benjamin becomes the general of the battle.)*

JOY: What's happening?

BENJAMIN: Bad guys, attack! Guys with purple jack hammers, over there! Red-orange flame throwers over there! Blue grenades, exploding into flaming yellow over here!

DOCTOR #1: I had no idea it was this bad.

DOCTOR #4: It's EVERYWHERE!

JOY: What do we do?

BENJAMIN: Try the bazooka!

JOY: Good idea.

DOCTOR #1: Try a little Tagamet.

DOCTOR #2: Maybe some Bactrum.

BENJAMIN: Let 'em have it!

*(They fire a medical Bazooka.)*

It isn't working.

DOCTOR #2: We've got to get out of here.

DOCTOR #4: We need reinforcements.

JOY: Command Central, request exit instructions.

BENJAMIN: You've got two choices: up to the lungs or down to my . . .

JOY and DOCTORS: Head for the lungs!

BENJAMIN: I'll cough you out!

*(He does so and they return to the hospital room, in exactly the same positions they held before beginning the Body Tour.)*

JOY: Now, that's an excellent map!

DOCTOR #4: I'll order up respiratory therapy to start Q - 4.

DOCTOR #1: I'll need some new X-Rays, Benjamin.

DOCTOR #2: Now we're ready for surgery. Thanks for your help, Command Central.

*(Doctors salute and exit.)*

JOY: You look tired. You want to rest for a bit?

BENJAMIN: Yeah.

*(She takes the X-Ray from him.)*

JOY: So, that's what it feels like. You sure are good at drawing.

BENJAMIN: Yeah. But I wish we could just erase it.

JOY: Erase what?

BENJAMIN: The hurt.

JOY: Me too. I'll see you tomorrow.

*(She hands him several pieces of drawing paper to go with his crayon, which he accepts. She offers her hand to shake with him - - and then fakes him out. Joy exits.)*

*(Doctor #2 brings in something to represent an IV pump and hooks it up to the bed. Doctor #4 brings in another.)*

DOCTOR #2: Command Central? New defense weapons.

*(They exit.)*

BENJAMIN: After surgery, I get a little better. Everybody smiles. Dad figures out how to put plastic lizards into old IV bags, so it looks like I'm getting lizard medicine.

*(Father does so.)*

Then, I get worse. No more smiles.

*(Voices of doctors as they move in and out of the room, checking.)*

DOCTOR #1: Colostomy complete, but he's bleeding into the abdomen now.

BENJAMIN: There are about a million machines in my room now, like robots standing guard round my bed.

DOCTOR #2: His white blood count is dropping.

BENJAMIN: I hear machines and voices all night long; whispering to me . . .

*(The night takes over, with Mother and Father on either side of the bed: a vigil. The monitors and machines whir and thrum and beep softly.)*

FATHER: Four A.M. Peace time.

MOTHER: Time to grab a slice of silence.

FATHER: Smooth brow, soft fingers, gentle breath. Almost normal.

MOTHER: So peaceful you can forget. Almost.

FATHER: Machines. *(Indicating medical machinery.)* Pumping food, pumping medicine, pumping blood . . . pumping hope?

MOTHER: And the sound. Like horses. Like galloping horses of hope in the night. I'm afraid of losing those horses.

FATHER: *(Trying to offer comfort and strength, for them both.)*  
 Busen lull, cook the kettle full,  
 There sailed three boats from the harbor.  
 The blue carried hope,  
 The red carried faith,  
 The yellow filled itself with love.

*(Time shift.)*

BENJAMIN: Mom! Dad! Look. Come look!

MOTHER: What is it?

FATHER: What's wrong?

BENJAMIN: Look at the moon. Just look at the moon!

MOTHER: I've never seen it so . . .

BENJAMIN: It's so big . . .

MOTHER: So close.

FATHER: So bright.

*(They climb into bed with him.)*

MOTHER: If I could be Queen of the World and have anything that I wanted . . .

FATHER: If I could be King of the World, and have anything I wanted . . .

BENJAMIN: I've never seen it so . . .

MOTHER: It's so big . . .

FATHER: So close.

BOTH: So bright.

*(Benjamin interrupts . . .)*

BENJAMIN: Dad, What's it like to die?

FATHER: What?

BENJAMIN: What will it feel like when I die?

FATHER: I . . . don't know.

BENJAMIN: Will it hurt?

FATHER: I don't kn . . . Probably. Some.

*(Pause.)*

MOTHER: I don't think more than now.

BENJAMIN: Where will I go?

FATHER: I don't know.

MOTHER: But it will be a new adventure.

BENJAMIN: Will you put me in a box?

MOTHER: What?

BENJAMIN: Will you put me in a box? You know, what's left?

FATHER: What do you want us to do?

BENJAMIN: I really want to be home again.

MOTHER: Then that's what we'll do.

BENJAMIN: Love you.

MOTHER and FATHER: Love you too.

BENJAMIN: And I'll always be your boy.

MOTHER and FATHER: Always.

*(Benjamin falls asleep, Mother and Father tuck him in, then exit. Doctors' voices come from outside the room.)*

DOCTOR #2: Orders?

DOCTOR #4: 800 units, packed red cells.

DOCTOR #2: Have you seen the latest liver results?

DOCTOR #4: Any change?

DOCTOR #2: Not for the better.

*(Time shift. Eddy enters, wakes up Benjamin.)*

EDDY: Hey, Benjamin. I got the bolts. See? I got some for me too . . .

BENJAMIN: Wow. Thanks Eddy. They're great.

EDDY: Don't you want to put them on?

BENJAMIN: *(He is tired, but he puts one on. )* Sure.

*(They do Frankenstein impersonations, but Benjamin is weak and starts to cough, scaring Eddy. Silence, as he looks around the room.)*

EDDY: Wow, you've got a lot more stuff here now.

BENJAMIN: Yeah.

EDDY: What's it all for?

BENJAMIN: So I can get better.

EDDY: Is it working?

BENJAMIN: I dunno . . .

EDDY: Really?

BENJAMIN: Really.

EDDY: Will you get better?

BENJAMIN: *(Shrugs "I don 't know.")*

EDDY: Are you going to . . .

*(Benjamin shrugs his shoulders, "yeah, maybe.")*

I never knew anyone that was . . . well, you know . . . going to . . .

BENJAMIN: Die?

EDDY: Yeah.

BENJAMIN: Well, now you do.

EDDY: Do your folks know?

BENJAMIN: Yeah, I think so.

EDDY: What's it feel like? To know?

BENJAMIN: Better than not knowing.

EDDY: I'm glad you're still my friend.

BENJAMIN: Me too.

EDDY: Benjamin. Can I have some of your Legos?

BENJAMIN: Sure. But not the castle.

EDDY: Deal.

*(Doctor enters to check the machines.)*

I'd better go. Will I see you later?

BENJAMIN: Sure. Sometime. Bye.

*(They do a very gentle high-five, Eddy exits.)*

*(Time shift. Doctors hook up another IV pump, then exit. Benjamin begins drawing, narrating as he draws.)*

BENJAMIN: This is a yellow brick road, leading from the gangplank of my boat, all along a long, long,

*(Joy enters.)*

JOY and BENJAMIN: long, long . . .

BENJAMIN: . . . rock wall. I walk and I walk, and my knee doesn't hurt a bit, and when I come to a gate, I meet a gardener. That's him. He tells me that the gate is locked, but I can squeeze through the bars if I want to. Because on the other side is . . . *(He draws a rainbow shape on the paper.)*

JOY: What do you see?

BENJAMIN: See? Here. That is for Momma and Pappa. But later. You'll know.

*(He continues drawing, she exits. Doctors begin to move in and out of the room constantly. There is an escalating sense of crisis.)*

BENJAMIN: Then I get worse. Everybody carries worry into the room and sadness out.

DOCTOR #2: Tuberculosis present, but we don't know the strain.

BENJAMIN: The oxygen tube in my nose makes it so I can whistle, and I could never whistle before! My heart starts doing a tap dance . . .

DOCTOR #1: Heart fibrillation! Get me an EKG! *(The doctors hook up another IV pump.)*

BENJAMIN: So they hook up a little TV with a blue squiggle and no commercials! And then I get worse, and everyone gets real serious. *(He quietly looks around the room.)* I sure hope heaven's not all white. 'Cause that would really be boring. It should look like this . . . *(He draws.)*

*(Sounds increase.)*

DOCTOR #2: Gradual enlargement of his heart muscle . . .

DOCTOR #1: Liver functions, way off . . .

DOCTOR #2: I'll up his oxygen level.

DOCTOR #4: *(Moving to the parents.)* It's like a brush fire. You stamp out sparks in one place, it flares up in another.

BENJAMIN: They put a red light on my finger, just like E.T.

DOCTOR #2: Internal bleeding is out of control.

BENJAMIN: Phone home! Phone home!

DOCTOR #4: It's just a matter of time. I'm so sorry.

BENJAMIN: The body part just can't keep up with the rest of me. So I tell it to let go. But I'm not alone.

*(Parents, Joy and Doctor enter and move to bed.)*

Almost time for the Yellow Boat to set sail.

FATHER: We'll all sail together . . .

MOTHER: I'll hoist the sails, Joy can do the anchor . . .

BENJAMIN: No. This time I have to go by myself.

MOTHER: Is there anything you want?

BENJAMIN: Just be here close. And a Dr. Pepper.

*(Benjamin's breathing becomes increasingly labored.)*

FATHER: Reach up and tickle the ceiling stars . . . makes it easier to breathe.

*(Benjamin reaches for the sky, and then "releases" into the arms of his parents. Time stops. After a beat, the doctors slowly unhook the IV lines and Benjamin slowly pulls away from the bed, on his way someplace else. The focus of the others in the room remains on the body left behind. Benjamin watches the scene he has just left as Joy steps forward and hands a drawing to the parents.)*

BENJAMIN: *(He colors the space with his words.)*  
I see red.  
I hear blue.  
I feel purple.  
I taste green.

*(Music underscores the last drawing, as the words and lights and images take us all to the "inside of a rainbow.")*

Last Drawing. The Captain decides that it's time for the Yellow Boat to set sail. I sail on the path the sun makes on the water. Then, the boat shoots up, straight up to the sun.



(He signs the final picture.) B-E-N-J-A-M-I-N.

(He jumps onto the boat, which is slowly surrounded by the unfurling rays of the sun. He has set sail. Musical resolution. Blackout.)

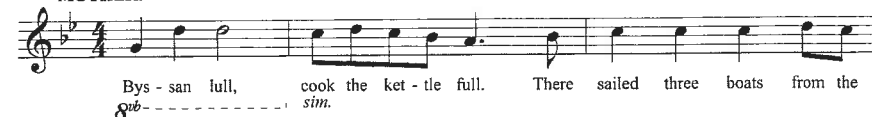
Vocal

## THE YELLOW BOAT

### Byssan Lull

Music - Evert Taube & Alan Ruch  
English lyric - David Saar

MOTHER:



MOTHER & FATHER:

